

A layman lost in the making of European standards

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A layman lost in the making of European standards

Between 2005 and 2010, the layman I was discovered the little-visible world of European standards-making. These were standards for Facility Management services, so-called "recommendation" standards, markedly different from the "mandatory" ones such as the "NF" mark for products.

The creation of a European standard for Facilities Management — strict FM, that is to say for building-related service offerings in the broad sense — was in the air. Given my experience of large IT infrastructure outsourcing operations, first as IT Director of a major international group and then as an independent consultant, I saw the risk that this standard might one day also be applied to IT and telecommunications outsourcing. The danger would then come from a standard drafted by specialists in "strict FM" alone, rather than by IT professionals. I convinced CIGREF to represent the sector at AFNOR in order to take part in drafting this standard. During the drafting process, it was interesting to clearly observe that the knowledge acquired through large IT outsourcing operations proved entirely applicable and beneficial to strict FM.

Establishing a standard is a long process, more than four years in this case. The process is in fact highly codified: the diagram shows the complexity arising from the number of actors and the successive validation stages at several levels. In short, starting from a request to create a standard by an FM service provider in the Netherlands, seven European FM standards were ultimately drafted thanks to numerous back-and-forth exchanges between the users of such standards. Steering — including compliance with the drafting rules, in particular the deadlines — is carried out by the permanent officers of each country's standards body, such as AFNOR in France, together with the European Committee for Standardization (CEN). Once approved at European level, they are translated into French standards for application in France.

This process can also quite naturally be extended to the worldwide level. Thus, today, the first two standards — the most general ones — are now only archives. Indeed, since their publication, they have been taken up and integrated into four ISO standards. Europe was a pioneer.

Why the method matters

- Analysing how a standard is developed — the method — is valuable for executives, in that it tells them the desirable level and type of involvement in such a process. In practice, if client representatives are absent or weak, the final standard will be unfavourable to them, and they will only realise it once it is applied.

1. Specific characteristics of the standards-making process

The whole process is strictly codified: forms, deadlines, the way rapporteurs are designated, the percentages granted to each country for the final votes (weighted by population, giving the large countries a very strong say). One example of a constraint: the impossibility of amending a plainly erroneous minutes before the "regulatory" one-year deadline.

Neutrality

The permanent officers of the bodies assigned to deal with a standard must remain strictly neutral.

The weight of words

A beginner discovers this quickly, because standards always begin with definitions. English is the working language. Thus the word "Facilities" has two meanings: that of "physical installations" and the more abstract one of "services". It is this latter meaning that is the one of the standards and that should be used for the translation. But given the common use of "Facilities" in French business, the English term was not translated! The English therefore benefit from an undeniable competitive advantage in getting their ideas across in the working groups. It is therefore permissible to hope that their departure from the European community will make the discussions more equal.

The weak representation of clients, theoretically the first beneficiaries of the standards

For suppliers and, to a lesser extent, consulting, standards concern their core business. As a result, they devote resources to them, both in number and in quality. For clients, these services are merely a tool, and it is difficult for them to devote resources to them in either volume or quality.

The obligation to close a working group's result by consensus

The rule for working groups is to arrive at a text with consensus among all participants. Two consequences: long discussion times and, in certain cases, a weakening of the proposed measures.

An opportunity for participants to expand their network

At the time, the two-day working meetings were not held remotely but took place in turn in a European capital. The participants were always very well received by the host country. So, after two or three meetings, business or simply friendly relationships could form.

Critical analysis of the standards

When the draft standards reached the stage of approval and the collection of any criticisms at country level, and then above all after consolidation at CEN level before finalisation, the discussions take place between the people who had worked on drafting these standards. One can easily imagine the difficulty for them of reworking the texts. The weight of the permanent CEN officer, with his imperative of impartiality, is then paramount, because he must provide a substantiated response to each criticism.

2. A few recommendations

To clients of standardized services

Clients undertake large FM operations only once every three or four years. They are in a position of weakness compared to suppliers or consulting. The latter, indeed, deal with the subject very frequently. Clients must therefore:

- band together to mutualise costs — for example around professional associations — so as to have qualified and seasoned representatives in the working groups, just as the other actors do, and this throughout the standard-drafting process;
- use the standards produced to obtain correct contracts from suppliers. A supplier can hardly free itself from recommendation standards. In particular, in a call for tenders the client can stipulate that the standards must be applied;
- use competent consultants judiciously — including those who took part in drafting these standards.

In this case, for FM, the suppliers much preferred to be paid on the resources deployed rather than to commit to results. It was therefore necessary to fight to restrict payment on the basis of resources engaged as much as possible, and so not to durably unbalance the supplier–client relationship.

To FM suppliers

The benefit of following the drafting from the very beginning can be to influence the content of these standards, but also to know their content in advance. It is then possible to organise accordingly, to develop services that meet the forthcoming standards, to train their teams, and to be able to highlight their competences in compliance with the standards.

To FM consultants

To be able to show clients that one is ahead of one's competitors and that one can help clients to anticipate.

3. Conclusion

Establishing a standard is thus a long and remarkable operation of collective, internationally-orchestrated intelligence. An in-depth survey of user groups on the actual use and value of these standards would probably be instructive.

— Guy Le Péchon

Sidebars

- FM — Facilities Management
- CIGREF — Club Informatique des Grandes Entreprises Françaises (IT club of large French enterprises)
- AFNOR — Association Française de Normalisation (French standards association); the standards mentioned in this article can be found on the AFNOR boutique website. By way of example: guidelines on how to draft facilities management agreements.
- CEN — European Committee for Standardization
- ISO — International Organization for Standardization

A reading recommendation

An article describing the value of standards for businesses: "Boards of directors: standards and certification" by Danielle Huet-Kuo, an extract from the book "Le Monde et la Gouvernance des ETI" (video) published by l'Harmattan — the article's author coordinated the drafting of this letter.

An illustration

Diagram of flows between standards-making organisations.

texte avec un consensus pour tous les participants. Deux conséquences : de longues durées de discussion et dans certains cas un affaiblissement des mesures proposées.

Une occasion pour les participants d'accroître leur relationnel : à l'époque les réunions de travail, de deux jours, ne se tenaient pas « en distanciel » à tour dans une capitale européenne. Les participants étaient toujours très bien reçus par le pays invitant. Aussi, après deux ou trois réunions, des relations d'affaire ou simplement amicales pouvaient se créer.

Analyse critique des normes : lorsque les projets de normes sont arrivés au stade de l'approbation et du recueil d'éventuelles critiques au niveau des pays, puis surtout après regroupements au niveau du CEN avant finalisation, les discussions ont lieu entre les personnes ayant travaillé à élaborer ces normes. On peut facilement imaginer la difficulté pour elles de remanier les textes. Le poids du permanent du CEN avec son impératif d'impartialité est alors majeur, car il se doit d'assurer une réponse étayée à chaque critique.

2. Quelques recommandations

Aux clients de prestations normées

Les clients ne mènent de grandes opérations de FM qu'une fois tous les trois ou quatre ans.

Ils sont en position de faiblesse par rapport les prestataires ou consulting. En effet, ces derniers traitent du sujet très fréquemment. Les clients doivent donc :

- s'unir pour mutualiser les coûts, par exemple autour de syndicats professionnels pour, à l'image pour les autres acteurs, avoir des représentants qualifiés et aguerris dans les groupes de travail et ceci tout au long du processus de fabrication de la norme.
- utiliser les normes produites pour obtenir des contrats corrects des fournisseurs. Un fournisseur peut difficilement s'affranchir des normes de recommandations. En particulier dans un appel d'offres le client peut stipuler que les normes doivent être appliquées
- à bon escient utiliser les consultants compétents dont ceux ayant participé à l'élaboration de ces normes

En l'espèce dans le cas du FM, les fournisseurs préféreraient de beaucoup être payés sur les moyens mis en œuvre plutôt que de s'engager sur des résultats. Il a ainsi fallu batailler pour restreindre le plus possible le paiement selon les moyens engagés et ainsi ne pas déséquilibrer durablement la relation fournisseurs-client.

Aux fournisseurs de FM

L'intérêt de suivre dès le début de l'élaboration peut être d'influer sur le contenu de ces normes, mais aussi de connaître leur contenu à l'avance. Il leur est alors possible de s'organiser en conséquence, de mettre au point des prestations répondant aux normes à venir, de former leurs équipes et de pouvoir mettre en avant leurs compétences dans le respect des normes.

Aux « Consulting » en FM

Pouvoir montrer aux clients que l'on est en avance sur ses concurrents et que l'on peut aider les clients à anticiper.

3. Conclusion

L'établissement d'une norme est ainsi une longue et étonnante opération d'intelligence collective internationale très encadrée. Une enquête approfondie auprès des groupes d'utilisateurs sur l'utilisation effective et l'apport de ces normes serait probablement instructive.

Guy Le Péchon

Encarts

FM : Facilities Management

CIGREF : Club Informatique des Grandes Entreprises Françaises

AFNOR : Association Française de Normalisation, les normes mentionnées dans l'article peuvent être trouvées sur le site à la boutique AFNOR. À titre d'exemple : [lignes directrices sur la façon d'élaborer des accords de facilities management](#).

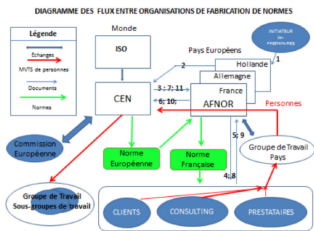
CEN : Comité Européen de Normalisation

ISO : International Organization for Standardization

Un conseil de lecture

Un article décrivant l'intérêt des normes pour les entreprises : « Les Conseils d'administration : Les normes et la certification » par Danielle Huet-Kuo extrait du livre « Le Monde et la Gouvernance des ETI » (vidéo) chez l'Harmattan coordination de l'élaboration par l'auteur de l'article de la lettre.

Une illustration



Original page 2, preserving the diagram and its surrounding layout.